

## So you're thinking about hospitality

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-eight careers on how exposed they are to AI.

**Kitchen and culinary work: 3.2 out of 10. Housekeeping: 3.0. Front-of-house: 3.6.**

**Reservations and customer service admin: 7.4.**

Everything that happens in front of a guest is protected. Everything that happens in an office behind them isn't.

And hospitality does something no other career in our index does — **it flips the pattern completely.**

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## The 60-second version

- Service and kitchen work is genuinely well protected. The guest is physically there and the experience is the product.
  - In most careers the entry jobs are disappearing. In hospitality the entry jobs are wide open and the shortage is at the **top.**
  - **76% of hotels are running short-staffed.** GM salaries went up 12.24% in one year.
  - The real problem is turnover: 70–80% a year, five times the norm — and three-quarters of it is people choosing to leave.
  - Which makes the strategy unusually simple: **the value is in staying.**
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## The flip

In every other profile we've written, the story is the same: the junior work is being automated, firms hire experienced people instead, and the way in narrows.

**Hospitality is the reverse.**

Industry analysis for 2026 found the biggest hiring challenge is no longer entry-level roles — it's experienced leadership. General managers, executive chefs, district managers.

Entry-level availability has actually improved. Hourly wage growth has cooled to 1–3%.

And GM salaries rose **12.24% year-on-year.**

**Why?** Because hospitality's junior work is physical and guest-facing — cooking, cleaning, serving. None of it was ever automatable the way document review or spreadsheet-building

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was. The entry rung was never at risk.

What thinned instead was the number of people staying long enough to *become* experienced.

So the shortage isn't an automation problem. It's a retention problem — and it's very good news for anyone willing to stay.

## The scores

| TRACK                                 | SCORE |
|---------------------------------------|-------|
| Housekeeping & facilities             | 3.0   |
| Culinary & kitchen                    | 3.2   |
| Front-of-house service                | 3.6   |
| Event operations                      | 4.4   |
| Hotel & venue management              | 4.8   |
| Revenue management & pricing          | 6.6   |
| Reservations & customer service admin | 7.4   |

**Notice which roles score badly.** Revenue management and reservations are the ones that look like promotions off the floor — and they score twice as high as the work you'd be leaving.

## What's actually being automated

Booking. Room pricing. Rota building. Stock ordering. Review responses.

All of it real work, and none of it the craft. Revenue management is the clearest case: pricing rooms against demand and competitor rates is a maths problem with structured inputs, and it used to be a skilled career.

**What can't be automated:** cooking the food. Cleaning the room. Reading a table that's gone quiet. Recovering a guest whose evening has gone wrong. Running a service when three things fail at once.

## The growth nobody mentions

Between 2020 and 2024 the hospitality workforce grew by **over two million people** — about 24%.

Within that:

- **Chefs grew 79.6%** — from 101,490 to 182,320
- Bartenders: **+53.2%**
- Bakers: **+37.3%**
- Cooks: **+30.9%**

And right now, **76% of hotels are operating short-staffed**, with the worst gaps in housekeeping, front desk, culinary and maintenance.

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## What we won't soften

Hospitality has the highest turnover of any industry in the United States.

- **70–80% annually** — roughly **five times** the 12–15% typical elsewhere
- The quit rate hit **4.3% per month** in March 2026 — highest of any industry BLS tracks
- **Three-quarters of departures are voluntary.** Layoffs are at 1.3%, matching the national average. This is people leaving, not being let go.

And the research on *why* is genuinely useful to you.

Pay is the most-cited reason. But **schedule unpredictability ranks equally or higher** among people who left — not knowing your shifts far enough ahead to plan a life.

**And the single strongest predictor of whether someone stays is the quality of their direct manager.** Better than pay, better than anything else.

**That's actionable.** It means when you're choosing where to work, the two questions that matter most are about scheduling and about who you'd report to.

**Also honest:** entry pay is modest and wage growth has flattened. Evenings, weekends and holidays are the working hours. And the employment picture has soft spots — full-service restaurant employment is still 174,000 jobs below pre-pandemic levels.

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## The strategy, and it's unusually simple

### Stay.

That's it. In an industry that loses 70–80% of its people every year, the market for someone with ten years of real operational experience is severely undersupplied. That's why GM pay is climbing 12% a year.

Alongside that:

**Learn the systems that replaced the back office** — revenue management, scheduling, inventory. Understanding what the system is doing, and when it's wrong, is what separates a manager from an operator.

**Judge the exceptions.** Dynamic pricing handles a normal Tuesday. It handles a citywide event, a storm closure or a bad review cycle badly. That judgment is the job.

**And learn to manage people well.** Since manager quality predicts retention better than anything, a manager who can hold a team together in this industry is producing real money — replacing someone costs 30–50% of their salary.

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## Does this actually sound like you?

It suits people who:

- **Get energy from other people** — for a whole shift, not for an hour
- **Perform well under time pressure** — service is a sustained sprint
- **Want to know immediately** whether they did well
- **Are physically robust** — long shifts on your feet
- **Want to run something.** The route to management and ownership is shorter here than almost anywhere.

Harder if you need predictable schedules — that's the top reason people leave — want evenings and weekends free, or find rudeness draining. Guests aren't always reasonable.

**And one honest thing:** hospitality can be a temporary job or a career. The people who do well are the ones who decided which.

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## When you're choosing where to work

Ask these. They matter more than pay:

- What's your annual turnover for this role?
- How much notice do I get for shifts, and how often do they change?
- Who would I report to, and how long have they been here?
- Who's been promoted from within in the last two years?

Full-service hotels typically run 40–60% turnover; quick-service restaurants sit at the top of the 70–80% range. That difference will shape your experience more than the job title.

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## Two things worth doing

**Work a full season including a hard one** — a Christmas period, a summer peak, a genuinely bad Saturday. Hospitality gets romanticised, and the reality is physical and relentless. It also suits some people completely, and you'll know quickly which you are.

**Then find two people:** someone who's been in it ten years, and ask what kept them. And someone who left after one, and ask what didn't.

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## One last thing

If someone has suggested this isn't a real career:

It employs two million more people than it did in 2020. Chef numbers are up nearly 80%. And it's one of very few fields where you can start at eighteen with no qualification and be running a venue at twenty-six — with no degree, no licence exam, and no debt.

The problems here are real. They're about conditions, not about ceilings.

Choose the employer carefully, aim at operations rather than the back office, and stay long enough to be the experienced one. That's the whole plan.

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**If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes**

- **BLS Job Openings and Labor Turnover Survey** — the government's own turnover and quit-rate data. Accommodation and food services is the highest of any industry, every single year.
  - **AHLA State of the Industry** — the 76%-short-staffed figure and the labour shortfall forecast. It's from the hotel operators' association, so read it knowing that.
  - **National Restaurant Association research** — employment by segment, including which parts of the sector are actually growing.
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*There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the turnover research in detail, what to ask an employer, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.*